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WEST COAST EDITION

End of an era as Harrow Ness light goes automatic

From our West Coast correspondent

The light at Harrow Ness, one of the most remote stations on the west coast, was this week converted to fully automatic operation, ending more than a century of continuous manned service on the isolated rock some forty miles from the mainland.

The station is among the latest in the Lantern Commission's ongoing programme to automate its most isolated lights, replacing resident keepers with remote monitoring equipment and self-contained power systems requiring only periodic inspection visits.

The move comes almost two years after the station's last keeper, Malcolm Teague, died in a storm-related accident in November 1986, a loss that campaigners within the keeping service say accelerated the case for automating the most

exposed and dangerous stations first.

Nobody who worked those rocks in winter needs telling why this had to happen eventually, said one former colleague of Mr Teague's, who asked not to be named. But it's still a sad day. That's a way of life ending, not just a job.

A Lantern Commission spokesman said the new equipment at Harrow Ness had been tested extensively and would maintain the same standard of service to shipping in the area without placing a keeper at risk. The station will now be visited periodically by inspection vessel for routine maintenance.

Harrow Ness becomes the ninth west coast station to be automated in the past three years.